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Journal of Homosexuality

ISSN: (Print) (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/wjhm20

Queer Reflections on AI: Uncertain Intelligences

by Michael Klipphahn-Karge, Ann-Kathrin Koster, and Sara Morais dos Santos Bruss, eds. New York, Routledge, 2023, 205 pp., $165.35 (Hardcover), ISBN 9781032405216

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To cite this article: Silpa Joy & Neerej Dev (02 Feb 2024): Queer Reflections on AI: Uncertain Intelligences, Journal of Homosexuality, DOI: 10.1080/00918369.2024.2310178

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/00918369.2024.2310178

Published online: 02 Feb 2024.

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BOOK REVIEW

Queer Reflections on AI: Uncertain Intelligences, by Michael Klipphahn-Karge, Ann-Kathrin Koster, and Sara Morais dos Santos Bruss, eds. New York, Routledge, 2023, 205 pp., $165.35 (Hardcover), ISBN 9781032405216

"Queer Reflections on AI: Uncertain Intelligences," curated by Michael Klipphahn-Karge, Ann-Kathrin Koster, and Sara Morais dos Santos Bruss, diverges from conventional artificial intelligence (AI) paradigms by integrating queer theoretical perspectives and broadening the discourse on its socio-political implications. This anthology pioneers in exploring AI's influence on gender and sexual identities, offering novel insights into how AI shapes societal norms and biases. Its multidisciplinary approach advocates for a more inclusive and intersectional analysis, foregrounding the importance of diverse perspectives in understanding AI's multifaceted influence. The introductory chapter lays the groundwork for an in-depth exploration of AI, emphasizing the need to consider its impact within a wider socio-cultural context. It highlights the convergence of AI with aspects of identity, power dynamics, and societal norms, revealing the technology's significant influence on these crucial human experiences. The book is strategically structured into three thematic sections: Genealogies, Materialities, and Speculations. Each section provides distinct perspectives on the interplay between AI and queer identities, enriching the reader's understanding of this complex relationship.

The *"Genealogies"* section presents an incisive critique of the historical, cultural, and ethical dimensions shaping AI, blending theoretical rigor with practical insights through the contributions of Blair Attard-Frost, Orit Halpern, and Nishant Shah. Attard-Frost's chapter on *"Queering Intelligence: A Theory of Intelligence as Performance and a Critique of Individual and Artificial Intelligence"* disputes traditional intelligence models by proposing a value-dependent cognitive performance approach to intelligence assessment in both human and AI contexts. This framework, emphasizing the interplay among agents, environments, and evaluators, effectively critiques the narrowness of current AI and cognitive science models but lacks a detailed exploration of how it could be operationalized in AI development.

Orit Halpern's *"Neural 'Freedoms': Population Choice and Machine Learning"* delves into the political and economic intersections of AI, tracing its roots to neoliberalism and alt-right ideologies. This understanding necessitates for a reorientation of technologies toward inclusivity and equity and, advocating for their recognition as not just an instrument, but as a significant entity that reflects and shapes socio-political realities. Halpern notes *"The future, I argue, lies in recognising what our machines have finally made visible, what has perhaps always been there, mainly the socio-political nature of our seemingly natural thoughts and perceptions."*, encapsulating how the understanding of "natural" thoughts and perceptions is significantly influenced by programmed systems, which are imbued with specific biases and intentions. The following chapter by Nishant Shah, *"I Spy with My Little AI: How Queer Bodies Are Made Dirty for Digital Technologies to Claim Cleanness"* dissects the intersection of AI technology with queer identities. Shah's critique of AI systems like Stanford's "gaydar" is compelling, highlighting ethical and scientific flaws in categorizing sexual orientation. The chapter robustly argues against AI's reinforcement of societal biases and queerphobia but fails to explore solutions or alternative that resist such biases.

Collectively, the section provide a comprehensive critique of AI, upending customary outlooks and advocating for an all-encompassing and ethically grounded approach. The anthology's strength lies in its interdisciplinary approach, effectively bridging AI with queer theory. A potential area for further exploration is the practical application of these theories in AI development and policy-making. Additionally, the "Genealogies" section could benefit from a more diverse range of AI applications and case studies to ground its theoretical arguments.

The *"Materialities"* section of the anthology delves into the tangible influence of AI on physical form and identity, featuring contributions from Ute Kalender, Michael Klipphahn-Karge, and Katrin Köppert. Ute Kalender's chapter, *"We're all cyborgs now?: Cripping the Smart Cyborg"* revisits the concept of cyborg within disability studies, emphasizing embodied queer knowledge. Critiquing on the use of disability as a narrative prosthesis that negate the true experiences of disabled individuals, Kalender emphasizes the need for AI and technology to be co-created with the input of disabled individuals. Furthermore, she aligns with the idea of "complex embodiment" by Tobin Siebers, suggesting a reductionist view of the medical model, which sees disability purely in biological terms, and the social model, which attributes disability solely to external societal factors.

In the next chapter titled *"Uncanny Bodies: Queer Subjects, Artificial Surrogates, and Ambiguous Robotics"* Michael Klipphahn-Karge examines the representation of queer identities in art through artificial surrogates. This chapter adeptly navigates the complexities of queerness and artificiality in art, addressing the tension between visibility and invisibility. While the exploration of these themes is insightful, the chapter could benefit from a more direct connection to AI technology beyond its artistic representation. A particularly striking proposition that encapsulates the essence of the discussion is: *"Through this kind of research practice, it becomes clear that even in an artwork like (Female Figure), which for the reasons explained is very controversial and clearly bound up in Western hegemonies, there are hidden possibilities for creating productive confusion in a world that standardised bodies in many ways and classifies them according to binary models."* Klipphahn-Karge asserts how artificial bodies in art can both perpetuate and disrupt stereotypical representations of gender. This exploration highlights the potential of art and AI to question and redefine the rigid binaries that dominate societal understandings of the body, thereby contributing to a broader discourse on the fluidity and ambiguity of identity in the context of queer aesthetics.

Katrin Köppert's *"Patching and Hoarding: Recodings of Period Tracking Apps"* critiques the datafication of feminized and reproductive bodies, focusing on period tracking apps, highlighting Tabita Rezaire's artwork and Luiza Prado de O. Martin's GIF essay as key elements in challenging the racial and gender biases inherent in these technologies. The chapter discusses how these apps often reflect and perpetuate neocolonial, misogynoir, and transphobic biases, particularly in their design and data algorithms, which predominantly cater to white, cisgender, heterosexual norms. The author proposes the concepts of "patching" and "hoarding" as aesthetic practices to critiqueand reimagine these technologies, advocating for a non discriminatory, queer, and decolonized approach to AI and digital reproductive health tools. The "*Materialities*" section collectively provide a critical examination of AI, challenging its portrayal as a universal solution and highlighting issues of algorithmic bias. The excerpt effectively underscores the need for a more affirmative approach to AI, considering its broader societal implications. However, future explorations could benefit from a more detailed analysis of how these insights can be translated into tangible AI development practices, ensuring that the theoretical critiques lead to practical advancements in the field.

The *"Speculations"* section comprises of three chapters that explores the transformative potential of AI in redefining human subjectivity and posthuman agencies. Sara Morais dos Santos Bruss's chapter *"Wild Science/Fiction: Conscious AI as Queer Excess in VanderMeer's Annihilation"* explores the concept of AI in the context of queer theory and decolonial thinking, using Jeff VanderMeer's "Annihilation" and its film adaptation as a case study. The author discusses how AI and machine consciousness are portrayed in these works, emphasizing their departure from traditional, positivistic knowledge production. The narrative of "Annihilation" is analyzed for its representation of AI as an immersive, environmental force that challenges conventional human subjectivity and categorical logic. The protagonist's transformation in the narrative is seen as a metaphor for the potential of AI to transcend rigid human categorizations, highlighting the fluidity of identity and the intertwining of human, natural, and technological realms. The chapter also looks at the potential risks of AI as an extension of colonialist and heteropatriarchal frameworks, while suggesting that a more comprehensive, queer understanding of AI could offer transformative perspectives on intelligence, knowledge, and identity.

Carsten Junker's analysis of the resurgence of manifestos in contemporary feminist and queer discourse through the chapter, *"Innovation and iteration: Queer Machines and the Tension between Manifesto and Manifestor"* brings a unique perspective to the anthology. The chapter analyzes several key manifestos, including the Cybertwee Manifesto, the Manifesto for the Gynecene, The Xenofeminist Manifesto, and Glitch Feminism, noting their creative approaches to blending feminist and queer theory with technological themes. Nonetheless, the author argues that while these manifestos seek to disrupt normative power structures and propose transformative futures, their impact is diluted by the frequent reiteration of the manifesto genre. This reiteration, while intended to be empowering and revolutionary, risks trivializing the imperative demands of these feminist and queer works, potentially echoing the traditional rhetoric of past manifestos rather than breaking new ground.

"AI as medium and message: The (Im)Possibility of a Queer Response" by Johannes Bruder offers an intriguing exploration of the complex relationship between autism, AI, and societal perceptions of intelligence. It discusses how AI, as both a medium and a message, perpetuates stereotypes about autism, particularly the notion of autistic individuals lacking social intelligence. The chapter highlights the paradoxical role of autism in AI development: while autistic cognition is used as a contrast to ideal AI, individuals with autism are increasingly recruited for AI-related tasks due to their perceived fit for repetitive and detailed work. This situation amplifies a problematic dynamic where AI both marginalizes and capitalizes on autistic traits. The chapter also examines the concept of "neuroqueerness," which challenges traditional views of neurodiversity and advocates for a more inclusive understanding of intelligence that is not solely based on normative standards. In conclusion, the *"Speculations"* section of the anthology provides a compelling assesment of AI's intersection with queer theory and posthumanism. The chapters collectively offer innovative perspectives and critiques, although they could benefit from a more focused exploration of how these theoretical insights translate into tangible AI applications and development. This section sets the stage for future research that could bridge the gap between theoretical speculations and practical AI implementations, further enriching the discourse on AI's role in society.

The final chapter, *"Inconclusion: Absent Presences"* by Os Keyes, acknowledges that queer individuals and theorists have historically used technologies for subversive purposes, pointing to potential for disrupting and reimagining AI. Keyes advocates for a shift in queer theory toward more active engagement with social movements and material activism, rather than focusing solely on cultural critique.

This involves embracing a "critical technical practice" where theorists are encouraged to participate in the design and building of technology, intertwining critical thought with practical application.

The book, through its diverse and insightful contributions, accentuates unresolved questions and emerging themes, reinforcing the urgency for a perceptive and mindful engagement with AI's evolving influence on both societal structures and individual identities. In the course of its intensive inquiry, *"Queer AI: Uncertain Intelligences"* significantly advances the discourse in both AI and queer studies, illuminating the intricate interactions with societal norms, cultural biases, gender, and sexuality, challenging the prevailing power dynamics and societal inequalities perpetuated by these technologies. By integrating queer theory into AI discourse, the book opens new avenues for future research, urging scholars and practitioners alike to consider the broader implications of AI beyond its technical capabilities. This approach fosters a more inclusive and equitable perspective in AI development and policy-making, potentially transforming societal understanding of AI. The anthology's call for a astute engagement with AI's influence marks a pivotal shift in how we perceive and interact with these technologies, advocating for a future where AI is developed and implemented with a keen awareness of its impact on diverse identities and communities.

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https://doi.org/10.1080/00918369.2024.2310178

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